



Ideas for India: Innovation Challenge 2026 Common Application form

Instructions:

- Each response field in the form has a specific word limit, and supporting files must not exceed 25 MB per file.
- The number of questions in the presentation should be limited to the outline provided – do not add any additional questions. If additional questions are added, then the same will be deleted to stick to the format and Management will not be held responsible in any manner
- The font type and size used to fill the presentation should be Calibri - Size 12

Section 1: Applicant details

Applicant or Team Member Name(s):	Harshil Patel, Deep Mehta, Meet Kapadia
Institution/College/Company/Startup Name:	Indian Institute of Information Technology (IIIT) Vadodara
Project / Solution Title:	Sahayak — A Voice-First AI Work Assistant for India's Deskless Workforce
Target Audience*	India's 400M+ deskless and frontline workers — nurses and hospital support staff, factory operators, warehouse and retail staff, field technicians — and the HR / operations teams of the enterprises that employ them (hospitals, manufacturing SMEs, logistics and retail chains).
Key Markets / Regions Served (e.g., Cities / States / Countries): (<i>Applicable only for Startups and Enterprises</i>)	Not applicable (pre-launch student team). Planned Year-1 pilot region: Bharuch, Gujarat — expanding across India thereafter.
Estimated Implementation budget:	₹10–12 lakh for a 6-month, two-site pilot: prototype-to-production development, cloud and LLM API costs, WhatsApp Business API fees, Indic speech-recognition usage, pilot deployment, training and support.
Select Type (highlight as applicable) *	☐ Student ☐ Professor ☐ Academician



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	☐ Professional ☐ Entrepreneur ☐ Other (please specify): _____
Problem Statement Applied Under (Select One)*	Inclusive Innovation for Bharat Expanding healthcare access, digital learning, and financial inclusion to improve quality of life.
Select the Industry your Solution Primarily Targets: (highlight as applicable) *	☐ Agri-Tech & Food Processing ☐ Cybersecurity & Digital Public Infrastructure ☐ Education & Skilling ☐ Advanced Manufacturing & Industry ☐ Green & Renewable Energy ☒ Healthcare & Health Tech ☐ Waste Management & Circular Economy ☐ Water & Climate Resilience ☐ Supply Chain & Logistics Tech ☐ Urban Infrastructure & Mobility ☐ Other (please specify): _____ <u>Other suggested categories</u> Inclusive Innovation for Bharat - Financial Inclusion, FinTech & Digital Payments - Assistive Technology & Accessibility Solutions - Social Impact & Community Development - Rural Development & Livelihood Enhancement - GovTech & Public Service Delivery
Annual Revenue (INR Crores) (Applicable only if you have selected "Entrepreneur" under select type)	☐ 2024 – 2025: _____ ☐ 2025 – 2026: _____

☒ I confirm that all applicant(s) are Indian nationals above 18 years of age (as on May 31, 2026).

Section: 2 – Case study details

Q.1. Describe the problem or challenge your solution seeks to address. Why is this problem important for India, and who is affected by it? (300 words limit)

An estimated 80–90% of India’s workforce — over 400 million people — is “deskless”: nurses and ward staff, factory operators, warehouse pickers, delivery riders, field technicians, security and retail staff.



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Yet nearly every enterprise tool ever built — HR portals, intranets, knowledge bases, ticketing systems — assumes an English-speaking employee sitting at a computer.

The result is a daily exclusion that is invisible to office workers. A ward nurse in Lucknow cannot quickly check her leave balance or shift roster. A machine operator in Pune facing “Error 42” cannot search the English-only PDF manual, so the line stays down until a supervisor is free. Workers do not understand payslip deductions, miss PF/ESI entitlements, and skip filing grievances because the process needs a portal, a password and English. Safety SOPs exist but go unread, contributing to accidents and compliance failures.

The burden falls on three groups. Workers lose time, money and dignity — they depend on intermediaries for basic information about their own employment. HR and operations teams drown in repetitive queries — industry studies suggest 40–60% of HR tickets are routine questions. Employers pay through attrition, machine downtime, safety incidents and lost productivity.

This matters for India specifically. Only about 10% of Indians speak English, while the workforces powering Make in India — manufacturing, healthcare delivery, logistics — are overwhelmingly non-English-speaking and mobile-only. India solved citizen-scale inclusion with UPI and Aadhaar; there is no equivalent inclusion layer inside the workplace. As India adds millions of frontline jobs this decade, the gap between “those with an HR portal” and “those with nothing” becomes a national productivity and equity problem — precisely the population Inclusive Innovation for Bharat aims to serve.

Q.2. Describe your idea (e.g., design thinking approach, community-led model, product or process innovation, etc). Additionally, how is your idea different, more practical, or more inclusive than existing solution to strengthen India’s position as a global manufacturing and innovation hub? (Max 300 words)

Sahayak is a voice-first AI work assistant that lives where India's workers already are: WhatsApp. A worker sends a voice note or text in Hindi, Gujarati, Hinglish or English and gets a spoken/text answer, a cited SOP step, or a completed HR action such as leave application, escalation or shift lookup.

The product has three layers. First, a multilingual voice interface removes English and literacy barriers. Second, a retrieval layer answers only from employer-approved SOPs, HR policies and worker records, with citations and an “I don't know” human handoff when confidence is low.



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Third, an action layer connects to HRMS/operations systems so the assistant can file requests, update supervisors and log outcomes.

The idea is design-thinking-led: we designed for the least-served worker first - low literacy, entry-level phone, patchy bandwidth and no portal training - and made that the default experience for everyone. Existing enterprise chatbots are usually English-first, web-based FAQ tools for office staff. Sahayak is worker-side, voice-first, code-switch-native and action-oriented.

For India's manufacturing and innovation ambitions, this matters because frontline productivity is the multiplier. When an operator gets a safe SOP answer at the machine, or a hospital worker resolves an HR query without leaving the ward, time, trust and compliance improve together.

Q.3. Explain how your solution contributes to the selected challenge theme. (Max 300 words)

a) If applying under Inclusive Innovation for Bharat:

How does your solution improve access, affordability, inclusion, or outcomes in healthcare, education, skilling, or financial inclusion?

Describe your solution and explain how it addresses the needs of underserved or marginalized communities, improves accessibility and user experience, promotes equitable access to services and opportunities, and delivers measurable social impact.

Sahayak contributes directly to Inclusive Innovation for Bharat across healthcare, skilling and financial inclusion.

Healthcare: the first deployment scenario is a hospital. Nurses and support staff get instant voice-based access to infection-control protocols, drug-handling SOPs, rosters and HR services in their own language. Faster protocol access and better-informed staff can reduce avoidable delays and safety mistakes.

Skilling: every answered SOP question is a micro-learning moment delivered on the job, at the moment of need. The supervisor dashboard converts repeated query patterns into a training-gap heatmap, helping employers decide which safety, machine or process topics need refresher sessions.

Financial inclusion: workers can understand payslips, deductions, PF/ESI contributions, leave balances and eligible benefits conversationally. This improves access to entitlements without requiring English, a desktop portal or HR dependency.

The underserved group is India's non-English-speaking, low-literacy, mobile-only workforce. Sahayak removes three exclusion barriers: language through Indic voice support, access through WhatsApp/entry-level phones, and trust through citations, explicit worker consent and human handoff for uncertain or sensitive cases.

Impact will be measured through first-contact resolution, reduction in repetitive HR queries, adoption among pilot workers, entitlement uptake, safety/escalation resolution time and worker



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satisfaction. The goal is practical inclusion: not a new portal for the already-connected, but workplace self-service for people currently left out of enterprise software.

Q.4. Mention the current development stage of your solution. Also, is it tested or validated? (300 words limit)

- ☐ ☐ Idea Stage
- ☐ ☐ Proof of concept
- ☐ ☒ Functional Prototype
- ☐ ☐ Simulation
- ☐ ☐ Pilot-Tested Solution
- ☐ ☐ Market-Ready

Briefly describe the same:

Current stage: functional prototype completed for hackathon demonstration.

What exists today: a working FastAPI + SQLite backend, WhatsApp-style worker chat UI, supervisor dashboard, deterministic multilingual intent engine, mock HRMS records, leave approval workflow, escalation queue, SOP retrieval with citation cards, language/intent analytics and a resettable demo database. The prototype runs locally without API keys and demonstrates Hindi, Gujarati and English flows.

Validation status: not yet field-tested with real workers or live enterprise systems. It has been internally tested through the prepared demo script: leave balance, leave filing, supervisor approval notification, SOP citation, Gujarati shift query, escalation and dashboard analytics. Post-challenge validation will be a 6-month two-site pilot, one hospital and one manufacturing SME, measuring resolution rate, HR ticket deflection, adoption, safety-query patterns and worker satisfaction.

Q5. What is innovative about your solution?

Describe the key innovation(s) that make your solution unique. Innovation may be in the form of technology, product design, business model, process, delivery mechanism, partnerships, community engagement, or any other approach.

Please explain:

- What makes your solution different from existing alternatives?
- How does it address the identified problem more effectively, efficiently, affordably, or inclusively?
- What is the most novel aspect of your solution?

Sahayak is innovative in five connected ways.

1. Voice-first, code-switch-native UX. It treats Hindi, Gujarati, Hinglish and English as normal workplace speech, not as translated menu options. Voice in and voice out make low literacy a supported mode, not an exception.



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2. Agentic HR actions. It does not only answer questions; it files leave, raises escalations, routes approvals and notifies workers, with explicit confirmation and audit trails.

3. Evidence-grounded SOP help. SOP answers come with source citations. If the system is unsure or the query is sensitive, it refuses to guess and hands off to a human.

4. Zero-install distribution. WhatsApp delivery avoids app rollout, passwords and training, which are common reasons frontline digitization fails.

5. Organizational learning loop. Repeated worker questions become a dashboard showing training gaps, SOP confusion, language mix and escalation hotspots.

The novelty is the combination: worker-side voice access, employer-specific knowledge, action completion and supervisor intelligence in one affordable system for Indian SMEs and institutions. Existing HR tools mostly serve office staff; Sahayak is built around the realities of a nurse, machine operator or warehouse worker using an entry-level phone during a shift.

Q.6. Briefly mention the exact outcome of your solution that aims to achieve:

Metrics	2024-25	2023-24	Unit / % Improvement
No. of beneficiaries served (monthly/yearly)	N/A (pre-launch)	N/A	Target: 2,000+ workers across two Year-1 pilot sites; 50,000+ by Year 3
Cost Savings / Efficiency Improvement (%)	N/A	N/A	Target: 30–40% reduction in repetitive HR/IT queries handled manually
Jobs created	N/A	N/A	6–8 direct jobs in Year 1; on-the-job upskilling for the entire pilot workforce
Environmental Impact	—	—	Secondary: paperless SOP, HR and grievance processes
Revenue / Economic Value Generated	N/A	N/A	Projected ₹30–50 lakh ARR by Year 2 (B2B SaaS)
Other Relevant Metric	N/A	N/A	First-contact resolution ≥70%; ≥60% monthly active adoption among pilot workers
Note - Please include only relevant metrics for your challenge			



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Q.6.1. Additionally, explain the most significant impact created or expected. (Max 150 words)

The most significant impact is giving India's 400 million deskless workers the same self-service access to their own employment that office workers take for granted — in their language, through their phone, without an intermediary. In pilots we expect: 70%+ of worker queries resolved at first contact; 30–40% of repetitive HR/IT workload deflected, freeing HR for higher-value work; measurably higher uptake of PF/ESI and benefit entitlements among low-wage workers; and faster, safer shop-floor operations as SOP knowledge reaches workers at the moment of need. At scale, Sahayak is a replicable inclusion layer for India's workplaces — the same playbook extends to public workforces such as ASHA workers and municipal staff, multiplying the social return.

Q.7. Have you collaborated or partnered with any NGOs, government bodies, startups, corporates, or academic institutions, etc in supporting your solution? If yes, describe the nature of the collaboration and its contribution to the solution. (Max 300 words)

Not yet — Sahayak is an early-stage project and no formal partnerships are in place. We have, however, mapped the collaborations the solution needs and will pursue them immediately: (1) Bhashini (MeitY's National Language Translation Mission) and/or Sarvam AI as the Indic speech and language backbone; (2) one hospital and one manufacturing SME as structured pilot partners, to be approached through our institution's network; (3) HRMS vendors popular with Indian SMEs (Keka, Zoho People, greyHR) for certified integrations; and (4) our institution's incubation cell for mentorship and pilot introductions. We will report the status of these collaborations transparently at each stage of the challenge.

Q.8. Explain the sustainability and scalability plan of the solution and mention the steps taken to make it inclusive and replicable in the future* (300 words limit)

Financial sustainability: Sahayak is B2B SaaS priced per employee per month (target ₹30–50 PEPM) — affordable for an SME with 500 workers (~₹15–25k/month) and scaling linearly with value delivered.



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Pilots convert to paid contracts; unit economics improve as speech and language model costs fall. We deliberately avoid ad- or data-monetization models: worker trust is the product's foundation.

Technical scalability: cloud-native and multi-tenant from day one. Three design choices make scale cheap: (1) a connector architecture, so each new HRMS/ERP integration is a module, not a rebuild; (2) language packs — adding a language is configuration on top of Bhashini/Sarvam models, taking us from 3 to 11+ languages without re-engineering; (3) WhatsApp distribution, so onboarding a 1,000-worker factory is a data-ingestion exercise, not a device rollout.

Market scalability: the same product serves hospitals, factories, warehouses, retail chains and facility-management firms with only content changes. India first; the model generalizes to any multilingual emerging-market workforce.

Inclusive and replicable by design: voice-first for low literacy; entry-level Android and low bandwidth supported; “I don’t know” plus human-handoff guardrails; privacy by design — consent-first onboarding, data minimization, an audit log of every action, and DPDP Act-aligned handling with anonymized analytics only. We will publish a per-vertical deployment playbook so the pattern can be replicated, including in public-sector workforces (ASHA and anganwadi workers, municipal staff) through government or CSR partnerships.

Steps already taken: architecture designed for multi-tenancy and language packs; pilot metrics defined (resolution rate, deflection, entitlement uptake); and two deliberately different pilot verticals selected (healthcare and manufacturing) to prove replicability from the start.

Q.9. Elevator pitch: Explain in a few lines why your idea deserves to be selected as a winner. Highlight what makes it unique, impactful, and scalable. (300 words limit)

Four hundred million Indians power our factories, hospitals and supply chains — and not one enterprise software product was built for them. Sahayak fixes that with the simplest possible interface: a voice note on WhatsApp, in your own language.

It deserves to win because it is: Inclusive by mechanic, not by mission statement — voice-first and WhatsApp-native, so a low-literacy worker on a ₹7,000 phone is a first-class user. Immediately practical — no app rollout, no hardware, deployable at a hospital or factory in days, with a working prototype



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demonstrated live. Genuinely agentic — it doesn't just answer; it files the leave, raises the ticket, and shows HR what the workforce doesn't know. Aligned with India's moment — it is the workplace layer of Digital India, built on public digital infrastructure like Bhashini, and it serves the theme's pillars directly: healthcare delivery, on-the-job skilling and financial awareness for low-wage workers. Scalable — one codebase, every vertical, every Indic language; from two pilot sites to a national inclusion layer.

UPI made payments work for every Indian. Sahayak does the same for the workplace.

Section 3: Documents

Attach documents – Create a google drive link that is accessible to all and attached the same here

Documents to be attached in the google drive link:

- Concept-to-prototype execution plan deck
- Demonstration Evidence – if any (Attach a demo video link)
- Team Details and Profiles
- Any other supporting

Attach google drive link here:

Pending before portal submission: paste the public Google Drive folder URL containing the execution-plan deck, demo video, walkthrough PDF, screenshots and team profile document.

Declaration*

- ☒ I/We confirm that the idea is original and developed by the individual/team.
- ☒ I/We agree to abide by the terms and conditions of the solution Challenge.